

Part I — Karma-kāṇḍa

प्रथमः षट्कः : ప్రథమ పట్కము

Action & the Self — Chapters 1 to 6 of the Bhagavad Gītā

The first six chapters of the Gītā answer one essential question: "Who am I, and what should I do?"

They form the **karma-kāṇḍa** — the section on **action and the self**. Across these six "yogas," Arjuna is shown that **he is not the body but the eternal Self (ātman)**, and that the way to live in this world is through **selfless, disciplined action (karma-yoga)** performed with **equanimity (samatva)**, not attachment to results. The journey culminates in **meditation (dhyāna)**, where the mind becomes "like a lamp in a windless place" — steady, undisturbed.

The six yogas of Part I — at a glance

CH	NAME (YOGA)	ESSENTIAL TAKE-AWAY
1	Arjuna-Viṣāda Yoga अर्जुनविषादयोगः అర్జునవిషాదయోగము "Arjuna's Despondency"	The spiritual journey often begins with a crisis — paralysis, doubt, grief. That collapse is not failure; it is <i>the door</i> . Arjuna's collapse on the battlefield mirrors every honest seeker's first moment of "I cannot do this anymore."
2	Sāṅkhya Yoga साङ्ख्ययोगः సాంఖ్యయోగము "Yoga of Analysis"	The Self (ātman) is eternal and indestructible ; only the body dies. Act from your duty (<i>svadharma</i>) without attachment to fruits . "samatvam yoga ucyate" — equanimity itself is yoga . (The Gītā in miniature — many traditions say if you only read one chapter, read this one.)
3	Karma Yoga कर्मयोगः కర్మయోగము "Yoga of Action"	You cannot escape action — even breathing is action. The solution isn't renunciation of work but renunciation of selfish motive . Act as <i>yajña</i> (sacrifice / offering), for the welfare of all (<i>loka-saṅgraha</i>).
4	Jñāna-Karma-Sannyāsa Yoga ज्ञानकर्मसंन्यासयोगः జ్ఞానకర్మసన్యాసయోగము "Knowledge & Renunciation of Action"	When <i>dharma</i> declines, the Lord takes birth, age after age (<i>yadā yadā hi dharmasya...</i>). Action illumined by knowledge — seeing inaction in action — does not bind.
5	Karma-Sannyāsa Yoga कर्मसंन्यासयोगः కర్మసన్యాసయోగము "Renunciation of Action"	Both paths lead to the same goal, but action without ego is easier and equally liberating as renunciation. The wise one acts but doesn't claim doership .
6	Dhyāna Yoga ध्यानयोगः ధ్యానయోగము "Yoga of Meditation"	Be your own friend, not your own enemy . Through steady meditation and moderation (food, sleep, work) the restless mind becomes still — "like a lamp in a windless place" (6.19).

The arc of Part I · Crisis (Ch 1) → Self-knowledge (Ch 2) → Selfless action (Ch 3–5) → Meditative stillness (Ch 6).

By the end of Chapter 6, Arjuna has been given a **complete contemplative path**: he knows *what he truly is, how to act in the world, and how to still his mind*. He is now ready to be shown the **Divine** itself — which is the work of Part II (Ch 7–12).

Devanāgarī

Telugu

IAST Sanskrit

Pronunciation

English Meaning

□ The essential verses of Part I (one per chapter)

BG 1.1 Ch 1 · The opening verse of the entire Gītā — Dhṛtarāṣṭra asks Sañjaya what happened on the battlefield

धर्मक्षेत्रे कुरुक्षेत्रे समवेता युयुत्सवः ।

मामकाः पाण्डवाश्चैव किमकुर्वत सञ्जय ॥ १.१ ॥

ధర్మక్షేత్రే కురుక్షేత్రే సమవేతా యుయుత్సవః ।

మామకాః పాండవాశ్చైవ కిమకుర్వత సంచయ ॥ ౧.౧ ॥

dharma-kṣetre kuru-kṣetre samavetā yuyutsavaḥ |

māmakāḥ pāṇḍavāś caiva kim akurvata sañjaya | |

"On the field of dharma, at Kurukṣetra — gathered, eager to fight —
what did my sons and the Pāṇḍavas do, O Sañjaya?"

The Gītā opens with the word *dharma*. The entire epic of 700 verses is framed as *dharma-kṣetra* — "the field of right action." Every human life is a Kurukṣetra.

BG 2.47 Ch 2 · The single most-quoted verse of the entire Gītā — the foundation of Karma-Yoga

कर्मण्येवाधिकारस्ते मा फलेषु कदाचन ।

मा कर्मफलहेतुर्भूर्मा ते सङ्गोऽस्त्वकर्मणि ॥ २.४७ ॥

కర్మణ్యేవాధికారస్తే మా ఫలేషు కదాచన ।

మా కర్మఫలహేతుర్భూమా తే సంగోఽస్త్వకర్మణి ॥ ౨.౪౭ ॥

karmaṇy evādhikāras te mā phaleṣu kadācana |

mā karma-phala-hetur bhūr mā te saṅgo 'stv akarmaṇi | |

"You have the right to action alone, never to its fruits.

Be not the cause of the fruit of action; nor let your attachment be to inaction."

□ See also: The detailed sheet karmanye_vadhikaraste.html covers this verse along with 2.48 (*samatvam yoga ucyate*) — full word-by-word.

✦ Word-by-Word — 2.47 (the foundation verse)

IAST	कर्मण्येवाधिकारस्ते	मा फलेषु कदाचन	PRONUNCIATION	MEANING
<i>karmaṇi</i>	कर्मणि	कर्मणि	KAR-ma-ni	in action / on action
<i>eva</i>	एव	एव	E-va	only, alone
<i>adhikārah</i>	अधिकारः	अधिकारः	a-dhi-KAA-rah	right, entitlement, jurisdiction
<i>te</i>	ते	ते	te	yours
<i>mā</i>	मा	मा	maa	not, never (prohibitive)
<i>phaleṣu</i>	फलेषु	फलेषु	pha-LE-shu	in the fruits / results
<i>kadācana</i>	कदाचन	कदाचन	ka-DAA-cha-na	at any time, ever
<i>karma-phala-hetuḥ</i>	कर्मफलहेतुः	कर्मफलहेतुः	KAR-ma-PHA-la-HE-tuh	the cause / motive of the fruit of action
<i>bhūh</i>	भूः	भूः	bhooḥ	be / become (imperative)
<i>saṅgaḥ</i>	सङ्गः	सङ्गः	SAN-gah	attachment, clinging
<i>astu</i>	अस्तु	अस्तु	AS-tu	let there be
<i>akarmaṇi</i>	अकर्मणि	अकर्मणि	a-KAR-ma-ni	in inaction

श्रेयान्स्वधर्मो विगुणः परधर्मात्स्वनुष्ठितात् ।

स्वधर्मे निधनं श्रेयः परधर्मो भयावहः ॥ ३.३५ ॥

శ్రేయాన్స్వధర్మో విగుణః పరధర్మాత్స్వనుష్ఠితాత్ ।

స్వధర్మే నిధనం శ్రేయః పరధర్మో భయావహః ॥ 3.3౫ ॥

śreyān sva-dharmo viguṇaḥ para-dharmāt sv-anuṣṭhitāt |

sva-dharme nidhanam śreyaḥ para-dharmo bhayāvahaḥ |

"Better is one's own duty, though imperfectly performed,
than another's duty well performed.

Better is death in one's own duty — another's duty is fraught with fear."

यदा यदा हि धर्मस्य ग्लानिर्भवति भारत ।

अभ्युत्थानमधर्मस्य तदात्मानं सृजाम्यहम् ॥ ४.७ ॥

యదా యదా హి ధర్మస్య గ్లానిర్భవతి భారత ।

అభ్యుత్థానమధర్మస్య తదాత్మానం సృజామ్యహమ్ ॥ ౪.౭ ॥

yadā yadā hi dharmasya glānir bhavati bhārata |

abhyutthānam adharmaṣya tadātmānaṁ sṛjāmy aham | |

"Whenever there is decline of righteousness, O Bhārata,
and rise of unrighteousness — then I manifest Myself."

▮ See also: The detailed sheet [yada_yada.html](#) covers this verse along with 4.8 (*paritrāṇāya sādḥūnām...*) — full word-by-word.

न हि ज्ञानेन सदृशं पवित्रमिह विद्यते ।

तत्त्वयं योगसंसिद्धः कालेनात्मनि विन्दति ॥ ४.३८ ॥

న హి జ్ఞానేన సదృశం పవిత్రమిహ విద్యతే ।

తత్త్వయం యోగసంసిద్ధః కాలేనాత్మని విందతి ॥ ౪.౩౮ ॥

na hi jñānena sadṛśaṁ pavitram iha vidyate |

tat svayaṁ yoga-saṁsiddhaḥ kālenātmani vindati | |

"In this world, there is nothing as purifying as knowledge.
The one perfected in yoga finds it of himself, in himself, in time."

भोक्तारं यज्ञतपसां सर्वलोकमहेश्वरम् ।

सुहृदं सर्वभूतानां ज्ञात्वा मां शान्तिमृच्छति ॥ ५.२९ ॥

భోక్తారం యజ్ఞతపసాం సర్వలోకమహేశ్వరమ్ ।

సుహృదం సర్వభూతానాం జ్ఞాత్వా మాం శాంతిమృచ్ఛతి ॥ ౫.౨౯ ॥

bhoktāraṁ yajña-tapasāṁ sarva-loka-maheśvaram |

suhṛdaṁ sarva-bhūtānāṁ jñātvā māṁ śāntim ṛcchati | |

"Knowing Me as the enjoyer of sacrifices and austerities,
the great Lord of all the worlds, the friend of all beings —
one attains peace."

यथा दीपो निवातस्थो नेङ्गते सोपमा स्मृता ।

योगिनो यतचित्तस्य युञ्जतो योगमात्मनः ॥ ६.१९ ॥

యథా దీపో నివాతస్థో నేంగతే సోపమా స్మృతా ।

యోగినో యతచిత్తస్య యుంజతో యోగమాత్మనః ॥ ౬.౧౯ ॥

yathā dīpo nivāta-stho neṅgate sopamā smṛtā |

yogino yata-cittasya yuñjato yogam ātmanaḥ | |

"As a lamp in a windless place does not flicker —
so is the simile used for the disciplined mind of the yogi
who practices the yoga of the Self."

✦ Word-by-Word — 6.19 (the lamp simile)

IAST	IAST	IAST	PRONUNCIATION	MEANING
yathā	यथा	యథా	ya-THAA	just as
dīpaḥ	दीपः	దీపః	DEE-pah	a lamp, a flame
nivāta-sthaḥ	निवातस्थः	నివాతస్థః	ni-VAA-ta-sthah	situated in a windless place
na īṅgate	न इङ्गते	న ఇంగతే	na IN-ga-te	does not flicker, does not waver
sā upamā	सा उपमा	సా ఉపమా	saa u-pa-MAA	this simile
smṛtā	स्मृता	స్మృతా	smri-TAA	is remembered, is taught
yogināḥ	योगिनः	యోగినః	YO-gi-nah	of the yogi
yata-cittasya	यतचित्तस्य	యతచిత్తస్య	YA-ta-CHIT-tas-ya	of one whose mind is controlled
yuñjataḥ	युञ्जतः	యుంజతః	YUN-ja-tah	practicing, yoking
yogam ātmanāḥ	योगम् आत्मनः	యోగమ్ ఆత్మనః	YO-gam aat-MA-nah	the yoga of the Self

□ If you remember just three lines from all of Part I:

1. *karmany evādhikāras te mā phaleṣu kadācana* (2.47)
You have the right to action, never to its fruits.
2. *samatvaṁ yoga ucyate* (2.48)
Equanimity itself is yoga.
3. *yathā dīpo nivāta-stho neṅgate* (6.19)
The yogi's mind is like a lamp in a windless place — it does not flicker.